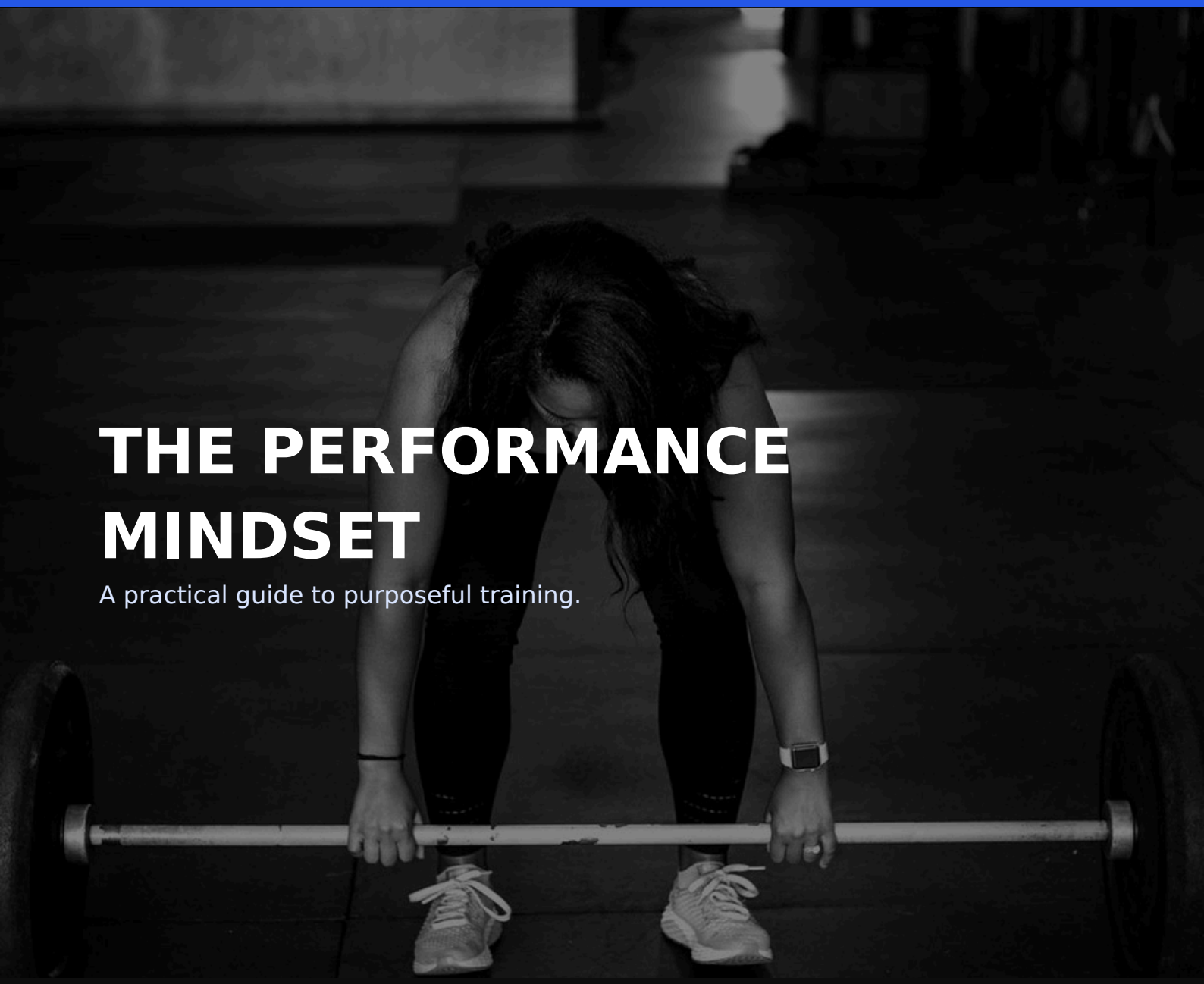


THE PERFORMANCE MINDSET

A practical guide to purposeful training.

BEN THOMPSON

FOUNDER / PRFMFITNESS



A NOTE FROM COACH BEN

For nearly 20years, I’vecoached peopleatvery different stagesof their fitness journeys: complete beginners, everyday gym-goers and competitive athletes. I’ve also built and led gyms in New Zealand and overseas.

Over the years, I've seen countless people dedicate their time and energy to improving their health and fitness, only to achieve a fraction of what they're capable of. It's disappointing to see that kind of effort go unrewarded, especially when a little more structure and direction could make such a difference.

All exercise is beneficial and has its place. Whether you're walking, attending a fitness class or simply being active because you enjoy it, you're doing something positive for your health and well-being.

But when you have a particular result you want to achieve, simply working hard isn't always enough. Having a clear goal and a structured training plan will generally give you a more effective and consistent pathway towards achieving it.

This book is about helping you understand that difference. I want you to understand the purpose behind your exercises, how progress is built and why training should make your life better, not take it over.

> **Effort matters. Direction matters too.**

You don’t need to become a competitive athlete. You can, however, borrow the mindset that makes athletes effective: define a goal, follow a plan, measure progress and stay consistent.



THE PERFORMANCE MINDSET

Let'sbe realistic. Everybodywants to lookgood naked.

There's absolutely nothing wrong with wanting to lose a few kilos, build some muscle or feel more confident about how you look.

But I've seen how making appearance your only measure of success can become a frustrating and sometimes mentally exhausting cycle.

Someone might work incredibly hard to lose 5 kg, feel great about it for a few days, and then immediately decide they need to lose another 2 kg. The goalposts keep moving, and what should have been a great achievement can quickly feel like it wasn't enough.

Over time, training can start to feel like a chore. Something you have to do rather than something you want to do. And when every gym session becomes another obligation, it's much easier to lose motivation and fall out of the routine altogether.

> **This is where performance goals can completely change your relationship with training.**

Instead of focusing solely on what you look like, start focusing on what your body is capable of doing.

> **Your first pull-up. 5 unbroken push-ups. Deadlifting your body weight. Running 5 km without stopping.**

These don't need to be enormous achievements. In fact, some of the most rewarding performance goals are the smaller ones you can achieve within a matter of weeks.

Every achievement gives you something tangible to celebrate and another reason to keep showing up.

You start looking forward to your training sessions because you're working towards something. You can see yourself improving, and those small wins build confidence, motivation and momentum.

One achievement leads to another. Before long, the gym can become one of the most enjoyable parts of your day rather than another chore on your to-do list.

And here's something I think is particularly important.

> **Athletes generally look the way they do because they're training to perform better at their sport. They don't train simply to look a certain way and hope it makes them better athletes.**

The physical changes are often a byproduct of the work they're putting in to become stronger, faster, fitter or more capable.

That's the approach I encourage.

Make performance your primary focus. Set meaningful goals, follow a structured plan and celebrate the improvements in what your body can do.

You'll often find that the aesthetic changes you're looking for develop alongside those improvements.

> **Train for performance, and aesthetics will take care of themselves.**



EVERY REP HAS A REASON

Atrainingsession ismore than alistof exercises.Exercise selection, order, load, repetitions, rest periods and recovery all influence the training stimulus, the specific challenge you place on your body.

Your body responds through adaptation, meaning it gradually becomes better equipped to meet that challenge. The type of improvement depends on what you train for: strength, endurance, movement skill or hypertrophy, an increase in muscle size, commonly called building muscle.

TRAIN FOR THE OUTCOME YOU WANT

This is the principle of specificity: your body adapts to the demands you practice. If your goal is a stronger deadlift, your plan needs appropriate strength work. If you want better anaerobic or aerobic cardiovascular fitness, your conditioning should develop that capacity.

The same logic applies to every training variable. Why this exercise? Why this load? Why these repetitions? Why this order, pace or rest period? There are many possible answers, but each decision should support the purpose of the session and the wider plan.

A useful question: What is this movement supposed to improve, and why am I doing it this way today?



THE SAME GOAL. 2 DIFFERENT APPROACHES.

Oneofthemostcommonthings I hearwhenmeetingsomeonenewis,"Ijustwanttoget stronger and fitter."

And there's absolutely nothing wrong with that.

But when I ask what getting stronger and fitter actually means to them, they often struggle to give me a clear answer.

It's a goal that sounds great, but what does achieving it actually look like? How strong do you want to become? How fit do you want to be? And how will you know when you've achieved it?

Let's look at 2 people who walk into the gym with exactly the same goal.

"I want to get stronger and fitter."

One approaches their workouts as exercise. The other approaches them as training. The difference isn't necessarily the exercises they perform or how hard they work. It's the intention, structure and progression behind what they're doing.

THE EXERCISER

Goal: "I want to get stronger and fitter."

They head into the gym and complete a workout that feels appropriate for the day, hoping that repeating it will eventually make them stronger and fitter.

- **Bike:** Ride for 10-20 minutes at a random comfortable or challenging pace, with no specific target.
- **Deadlift:** Perform roughly 3-5 sets of 5-10 repetitions with a weight that feels tiring.
- **Push-ups:** Perform around 3 sets of as many repetitions as possible, without a consistent movement standard or progression.

Week 2 and Week 3 might look much the same. They may improve, but they have no clear way to measure progress.

THE PERSON TRAINING

Goal: "I want to get stronger and fitter."

Exactly the same starting point. But rather than leaving it there, we turn that general goal into something specific and measurable.

First, we establish what the person can currently do. Then we identify performance benchmarks that represent the improvements they want to achieve:

- **Strength:** Deadlift their body weight of 65 kg. Currently capable of approximately 35 kg for 7 repetitions.
- **Bodyweight strength:** Perform 5 full-range push-ups on the floor. Currently unable to complete 1.
- **Cardiovascular fitness:** Improve fitness for indoor social netball, which involves repeated medium- to high-intensity bursts, frequent stopping, starting and changes of direction. Currently able to play for around 4 minutes before needing to be substituted off due to fatigue.

We've taken the same general ambition and given it measurable outcomes. Now we can build a plan around them, track progress and make informed adjustments.

> **The goal hasn't fundamentally changed. We've simply defined what achieving it actually looks like.**



3 EXERCISES. A PURPOSEFUL PLAN.

Thefollowing3-week examplesillustratehowaprogramcanprogress.They'reteachingexamples,not a complete individual prescription.

THE DEADLIFT PLAN

The aim is to develop strength while maintaining technique and control. Begin with 2 lighter warm-up sets before the working sets.

	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3
Working sets	3 × 5	3 × 5	3 × 5
Load	37.5 kg	40 kg	42.5 kg
Rest	Around 2 min	Around 2 min	Around 2 min
Focus	Consistent technique	Quality at a heavier load	Controlled progression

RPE (rate of perceived exertion): In plain English, a 1-10 scale describing how hard an effort feels. In resistance training, RPE 8 commonly means around 2 repetitions left in reserve. This should feel quite challenging, getting close to muscular failure, but not actually reaching it.

RPE can help match the load to your readiness on the day. The increasing weights shown here are possible progressions, not requirements. Add weight only when technique, effort and recovery support it. Sometimes repeating the same load is the right decision.

THE PUSH-UP PLAN

Our trainee cannot yet perform a full range push-up on the floor. Rather than repeatedly attempting incomplete repetitions, we make the movement more accessible by placing their hands on a stable elevated surface.

	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3
Sets × reps	4 × 10	4 × 8	5 × 6
Hand height	Higher	Slightly lower	Lower again, if ready
Focus	Full range and control	Harder angle, same quality	Appropriate challenge

Lowering the hands generally makes the push-up more difficult. Repetitions decrease as difficulty increases, so the total number of repetitions isn't the same each week. The progression is in movement difficulty, not equal volume.

Regression and progression: A regression makes an exercise more accessible. A progression makes it more demanding. Scaling isn't failure. It helps you practice the right movement at the right difficulty.

THE CYCLING PLAN

The bike session alternates 2 minutes at a working pace with easy pedaling. Keep cycling throughout, including after the final work interval.

	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3
Rounds	5	5	6
Work	2 min medium	2 min medium	2 min hard
Easy pedaling	90 sec	60 sec	60 sec
Total time	17:30	15:00	18:00
Target	Similar distance in each effort	Match Week 1 distance with less recovery	Improve on Week 2 distances consistently

Week 1 establishes a repeatable output. Week 2 challenges recovery by reducing the easy pedaling time. Week 3 increases the number and intensity of work intervals, aiming to improve distance without a dramatic drop-off between efforts.

The Week 2 session is shorter overall, but shorter recovery can still make the work more demanding. This is progression without adding weight.



PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD

Progressive overloadmeansdeliberatelyadjusting trainingdemandsover time so your body continues to receive an appropriate stimulus, a challenge that encourages it to adapt. It doesn't mean making every workout more exhausting.

Increasing the weight on a deadlift is one example. But you can also progress by changing repetitions or sets, adjusting work and recovery periods, improving movement range or control, or making an exercise more demanding, as we saw with the push-ups and cycling.

These are examples, not an exhaustive list. Exercise order and pre-fatigue can also change the challenge, although not every change is necessarily a productive progression. What matters is whether the adjustment supports the outcome you're training for.

THE RIGHT CHALLENGE AT THE RIGHT TIME

Change too much too soon and technique, performance or recovery may suffer. Change too little for too long and progress can slow. A harder workout isn't automatically a better one.

Good programming allows you to progress when appropriate, repeat a session when useful, or reduce the demand when needed.

THE ART IN THE PROGRAMMING

Progressive overload isn't simply adding weight or repetitions every week. It's applying the right amount of challenge at the right time.

And this is where coaching experience becomes valuable. Not everything can be predicted or measured on a spreadsheet. Sometimes you need to watch how someone moves, understand how they're responding to training and use previous results to make an educated decision about what comes next.

There are times to push forward, times to hold steady and times to pull things back. A program provides the structure, but knowing when and how to adjust it is what I call **the art in the programming**.

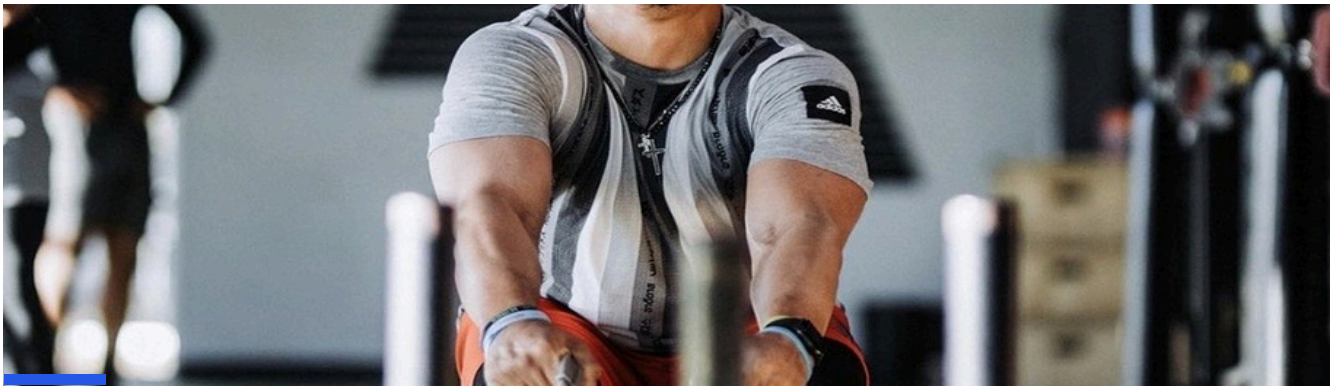
It's what separates thoughtful coaching from simply following a formula, whether that's a spreadsheet, a generic training template or AI.

THE ART IN THE PROGRAMMING

The science gives us the principles.

The art is knowing how and when to apply them.

Thoughtful coaching. Purposeful progress.



THE BIGGER PLAN

Agoodtraining programdoesn't just consider whatyou're doing today. It considers how today's session contributes to what you're trying to achieve in 3 weeks, 3 months or even 12 months.

In coaching, we often break training into 3 levels:

Microcycle: Your weekly plan. Usually around 1 week of training. This is where we organize individual sessions, harder and easier days, and recovery.

Mesocycle: Your training phase. A block of several weeks focused on developing particular qualities, such as strength, muscular endurance or cardiovascular fitness.

Macrocycle: Your long-term plan. The bigger picture, often spanning several months or longer. This connects your shorter training phases to your overall goals.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

Think back to our 3-week deadlift, push-up and cycling examples. Each week represents a microcycle. Those 3 weeks could form part of a larger mesocycle, which in turn contributes to a longer-term goal.

This is why good programming involves more than choosing exercises. We need to consider how training sessions build upon each other, how much recovery is required and when to increase or reduce the challenge.

WHEN PROGRESS DOESN'T GO TO PLAN

Progress is rarely perfectly linear. Some weeks you'll improve faster than expected. Other weeks you might struggle to match your previous performance.

That doesn't automatically mean your program isn't working. Sometimes the answer is to increase the challenge. Sometimes it's to improve technique, adjust an exercise, allow more recovery or simply give your body more time to adapt.

> **A good training plan provides direction without being so rigid that it ignores the person following it.**



CONSISTENCY IS KEY

I'd much ratherseesomeonetrain2or 3 times a week, consistently for an entire year, than train 6 days a week for 12 weeks, burn themselves out and give up altogether.

One of the biggest mistakes people make when starting a new training program is trying to do too much, too soon.

They start with the best intentions. They're motivated, excited and ready to make a change. So they commit to training 5 or 6 days a week, completely overhaul their diet and try to change every aspect of their lifestyle overnight.

For some people, that might work. But for many, it's simply not sustainable.

Life gets busy. Work gets stressful. Family commitments come up. Suddenly, the routine they've created becomes difficult to maintain, and before long, they're back where they started.

> **A good training program should fit around your life, not require you to build your entire life around it.**

BUILD A ROUTINE YOU CAN MAINTAIN

Start by being realistic about how much time you can consistently dedicate to training.

If that's 2 sessions a week, fantastic. Make those 2 sessions count.

If you can comfortably manage 4, great. But don't confuse doing more with automatically getting better results.

The important thing is that your training has purpose, follows a structured plan and allows you to make progress over time.

And remember, consistency doesn't mean perfection.

Missing a session occasionally isn't going to undo your progress. Neither is taking a holiday, having a busy week at work or needing some additional recovery.

What matters is what you do consistently over months and years, not whether every individual week goes exactly to plan.

RECOVERY AND NUTRITION MATTER TOO

Your progress isn't determined solely by what happens inside the gym.

Getting enough sleep, eating appropriately to support your goals and allowing your body time to recover are all important parts of the process.

You don't need to follow the latest restrictive diet or completely overhaul the way you eat.

Focus on building sensible, sustainable habits that support your training and that you can maintain long term.

> **You don't need to be perfect. You just need to keep showing up.**



IGNORE THE NOISE

Thefitness industry hasno shortage ofpeopletellingyou what you should be doing.

Every time you open social media, there's another exercise you apparently need to try, a new training method promising incredible results or someone claiming they've discovered the secret to getting stronger, leaner or fitter.

Some of this information is genuinely useful. But there's also plenty of rubbish out there.

And for someone who's just getting started, trying to figure out what's actually worth listening to can be incredibly confusing.

The reality is that getting results doesn't need to be complicated.

You don't need to perform the latest exercise you've seen on Instagram, follow every new fitness trend or completely change your training because somebody online claims their method is better.

> **A good training program doesn't need to look impressive. It needs to be effective.**

Before copying an exercise or workout you've seen online, ask yourself a few simple questions:

- What am I actually trying to improve?
- Is this appropriate for my current ability?
- How will I measure whether I'm getting better?
- Does it fit into my overall training plan?
- Can I consistently repeat and progress it?

If you can't answer those questions, it's worth considering whether that exercise belongs in your program in the first place.

THE GYM IS FOR EVERYBODY!

I completely understand why walking into a gym for the first time can feel intimidating.

You're surrounded by unfamiliar equipment, people who seem to know exactly what they're doing and perhaps a few individuals lifting weights you couldn't imagine moving yourself.

It's easy to feel like everybody knows what they're doing except you.

And while gyms often promote themselves as friendly, welcoming and non-intimidating environments, that's a difficult message to communicate through a photo, an advertisement or a social media post.

It's something you really need to experience for yourself.

What many people don't realise is that some of the strongest friendships and communities are built inside gyms, through training together, supporting one another and celebrating each other's achievements.

The person lifting twice their body weight was once a beginner too. Everybody starts somewhere.

You don't need to get fit before joining a gym, and you certainly don't need to know what you're doing before walking through the doors.

> **The gym is a place to learn, improve, challenge yourself and enjoy the process. And there's room for everybody.**



WHAT WOULD YOU LIKE TO ACHIEVE?

When I sit down with someone foran initialconsultation, I'moftenless interested inasking whattheir fitness goals are and more interested in finding out what they'd actually like to be able to do.

What would you love to achieve?

What's something you think would be pretty cool to do?

Where would you like to see yourself in 6 or 12 months?

What's something you've always wanted to try but never thought you'd be physically capable of?

These questions often lead to far more interesting conversations than simply asking whether someone wants to lose weight, build muscle or get fitter.

WHAT'S HOLDING YOU BACK?

Another question I regularly ask is:

What limitations do you currently feel your body has?

Maybe you struggle to get off the floor, pick up your child or carry all the groceries from the car in 1 trip.

Perhaps you've avoided hanging from a pull-up bar because of your grip strength, or you've ruled out a sport or activity because you don't feel physically capable.

These are just examples. For someone new to training, getting off the floor comfortably might be a significant achievement. For someone more experienced, it might be running a marathon, deadlifting twice their body weight or mastering a difficult gymnastics movement.

> **The level of difficulty changes. The principle stays the same.**

I believe your body should open doors, not close them.

Some physical limitations are very real, but others are things we've simply accepted without questioning whether we could improve them.

And sometimes, the biggest challenge is believing that something is even possible.

BIG ACHIEVEMENTS START WITH SMALLER ONES

Here's an example I like to use when coaching.

I'll ask someone:

"Wouldn't it be pretty cool to perform a muscle-up?"

The answer is usually yes.

Then I'll ask:

"What other exercises do you think someone who can perform a muscle-up would probably be pretty good at?"

Pull-ups, push-ups, dips, grip strength, hanging movements, body control. The list goes on.

Suddenly, that 1 impressive movement represents a whole collection of smaller abilities we can start developing.

Rather than seeing the muscle-up as something completely out of reach, we can work backwards and break it into manageable steps.

THE ROAD TO YOUR FIRST MUSCLE-UP

The big achievement: Perform your first muscle-up.

Step 5: Chest-to-bar pull-ups, strong bodyweight dips and muscle-up transition practice.

Step 4: Full-range pull-ups and controlled dips.

Step 3: Assisted pull-ups, full-range push-ups and harder rowing variations.

Step 2: 30-60 second bar hangs, elevated push-ups and bodyweight rows.

Step 1: Ring/TRX rows, shoulder taps and appropriately scaled push-ups.

This is an illustrative progression rather than a strict sequence. The actual steps depend on the individual and the type of muscle-up.

But look at everything you're developing along the way: strength, coordination, grip, stability and confidence.

Even before you achieve the muscle-up, you've become more capable across a whole range of movements.

And every smaller achievement gives you another reason to keep training.

NOW THINK ABOUT YOURSELF

> **What would you love to achieve in the next 6 to 12 months?**

What physical limitations are currently holding you back?

What's something you've always wanted to try but haven't felt capable of doing?

What's 1 smaller achievement you could start working towards?

You don't need to limit yourself to 1 ambition. Start with a few things that genuinely matter to you, then identify the smaller steps that will help you get there.

Train to build a body that's capable of doing more of the things you want to do.



SMALL WINS = BIG GOALS

Now that you've startedthinkingaboutwhatyou'dlovetoachieve,let'sbreak it down into something you can actually work towards.

I like to start with the big picture and work backwards.

THE BIG ACHIEVEMENT

What would be really cool to accomplish?

Choose 1 big achievement that genuinely excites you. Something challenging enough to make you a little nervous, but something you'd love to accomplish. This might take 9-12 months or longer, and that's absolutely fine.

My 1 big achievement:

YOUR STEPPING STONES

What could you achieve in the next 4-6 months?

Think about 2 or 3 meaningful achievements that would help you develop the abilities you'll need for your big ambition. They don't have to be halfway points. They just need to move you forward.

My stepping stones:

YOUR FIRST SMALL WINS

What could you achieve in the next 1-3 months?

Choose 4 or 5 smaller achievements that build towards your stepping stones. Challenging but realistic. Something you can start making progress on in the coming weeks.

My small wins:

NOW CONNECT THE DOTS

Your small wins develop the abilities required for your stepping stones, which move you closer to the big achievement.

The timeframes are guides, not deadlines. Some things will happen faster than expected, while others take longer. And while it helps to have 1 main destination, you can still enjoy other achievements along the way.

> **Big achievements become a lot less intimidating when you can see the smaller steps that will get you there.**



YOUR NEXT 30 DAYS

You'veidentifiedwhatyou'dlovetoachieveandbrokenthose bigger ambitions into smaller, manageable steps.

Now it's time to put those ideas into practice.

The next 30 days aren't about transforming your fitness overnight. They're about building consistency, training with purpose and creating some momentum.

WEEK 1: ESTABLISH YOUR STARTING POINT

Look back at the small wins you've identified and choose 1 or 2 to focus on.

Establish what you're currently capable of doing and record something measurable, whether that's repetitions, weight lifted, distance covered or the quality of a particular movement.

Commit to a realistic weekly training schedule that you can maintain.

Your focus: Know where you're starting and have a plan for moving forward.

WEEK 2: MAKE EVERY REP COUNT

Before each training session, ask yourself:

> **"How is today's training helping me become better at something?"**

Every exercise should have a purpose. Whether you're developing strength, improving fitness or learning a new skill, understand why you're doing it and how it contributes to your bigger ambitions.

Focus on quality, follow your program and record your results.

Remember, the performance mindset isn't about being an elite athlete. It's about approaching your training with the same intention and direction.

Your focus: Don't just complete the workout. Understand what you're trying to achieve.

WEEK 3: RECOGNISE THE SMALL WINS

By now, you might be noticing improvements.

An extra repetition, better movement control, a slightly heavier weight or faster recovery between efforts.

These are all signs of progress worth recognising.

Not every session needs to be better than the last. Sometimes progress means repeating a performance with better technique or allowing your body more time to adapt.

Your focus: Recognise improvements and make sensible adjustments when needed.

WEEK 4: REVIEW AND LOOK AHEAD

Revisit your starting point and compare your results under similar conditions.

What improved? What still needs work? What have you learned about your training?

Celebrate the progress you've made, even if you haven't achieved your first small win just yet.

Then decide what you'd like to work towards over the next 30 days.

Your focus: Learn from the last 30 days and use that information to guide the next 30.

YOUR 30-DAY CHECK-IN

My 1 or 2 priorities:

My starting point:

My weekly training commitment:

What improved over the last 30 days?

What will I work towards next?

YOUR NEXT 30 DAYS

Your training log should tell a story, not just list what you did.

Every session has a reason. Every repetition is an opportunity.



THE PRFM APPROACH

I've always believedthateveryonedeservestounderstandtheirtraining, not just be handed a workout and told to get on with it.

That's the philosophy behind PRFM Fitness.

You don't need to be a competitive athlete to benefit from good programming. Whether you're just getting started or have been training for years, the principles remain the same.

Know what you're working towards. Understand why you're doing what you're doing. Follow a plan that challenges you appropriately, and recognise the progress you make along the way.

Most importantly, enjoy the process.

Training should be something you look forward to. Something that challenges you, builds confidence and helps you become more capable of doing the things you love.

> **Your body should open doors, not close them.**

If this book has helped you think differently about your training, then it's done exactly what I hoped it would.

And if you'd like some help putting these principles into practice, that's exactly what we're building at PRFM Fitness.

Train with purpose.

Ben Thompson Founder, PRFM Fitness

www.prfmfitness.com